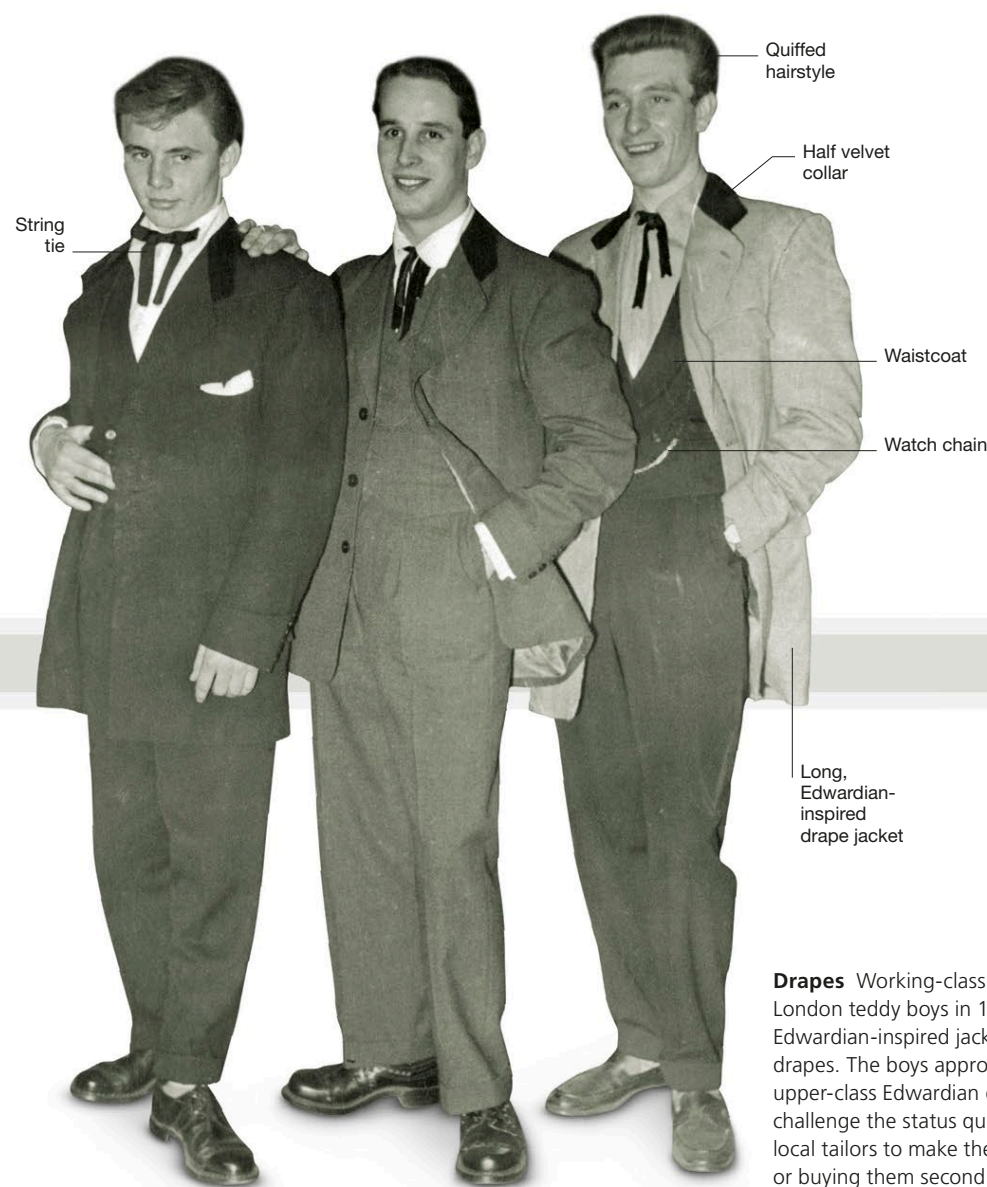


1950–1959

HIPSTERS AND TEDDY BOYS

Two distinct, mainly male, style tribes, hipsters and teddy boys both dressed in ostentatious suits to rebel against the social order. The original hipsters were African-Americans who emulated the lifestyle and clothing of “bebop” jazz musicians of the late 1930s and early 40s. Their fashion uniform was the zoot suit, consisting of high-waisted trousers with a baggy leg that tapered dramatically to a narrow cuff, and a long, generously cut jacket with a wide lapel and padded shoulders. It was usually worn with a gold watch chain, a broad-brimmed felt hat, and two-tone or pointed shoes. Across the Atlantic, teddy boys were working-class London teenagers, listening to American rock ‘n’ roll but usurping the Edwardian suit revival on Savile Row to invent their own style. They wore flamboyant, Edwardian-cut jackets with waistcoats, string ties, and pegged trousers. Teddy girls mixed these masculine elements with feminine accessories.



Drapes Working-class London teddy boys in 1954 wear Edwardian-inspired jackets called drapes. The boys appropriated upper-class Edwardian dress to challenge the status quo, using local tailors to make their suits or buying them second hand.



Duster coat The teddy boy style spread across Britain, drawing on what was available locally. This young man, photographed in Derbyshire in 1957, wears a simple coat more suggestive of working-class utility than Savile Row tailoring.



Style mix A 17-year-old teddy girl poses in 1955. Teddy girls were early adopters of American teen basics such as jeans and ballet pumps. They mixed them with clothing styles from the Edwardian and Victorian eras.